



TARANTULA · THERAPHOSIDAE

Keep your tarantula the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual for the beginner tarantulas: the Chilean rose hair, the curly hair and their ground-dwelling relatives, and the tree-dwelling pink toe. An enclosure built low so a fall can't kill, the water that prevents the most common cause of death, molting read correctly, and the law in every state.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every size and temperature in both systems, sized to leg span
- ✓ Molting, fasting, and the dehydration that is the real emergency
- ✓ Sling housing, the pink toe's tall enclosure, and a safe rehousing method
- ✓ Owner logs, a molt log, a pet-sitter sheet and an emergency card

49 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) with centimeters (cm) beside them, and a tarantula is measured by its leg span, diagonally from the tip of a front leg to the tip of the opposite back leg. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Sling containers are sold by volume, in drams for vials and ounces for cups. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 25: a tarantula is legal with no permit in most of the United States, but a few places bar it and one state clears only three species. Then read pages 4 to 11 before buying anything. The enclosure shape is the decision that kills tarantulas: a ground-dweller in a tall enclosure has somewhere to fall from. Use the Budget & Shopping List on page 34 to buy once.

If your tarantula is already home

Audit the setup against the Setup Checklist on page 32, paying most attention to fall height, substrate depth and the water dish. If your spider has stopped eating, read page 15 before you worry: for a tarantula, weeks without food are usually normal. A shrunken, wrinkled abdomen is the real emergency, and it is on page 27.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 32: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 39: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 33: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 40: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Pages 41 and 42: Molt Log, Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Daily, Weekly & Yearly Routine | ☐ Page 43: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHICH TARANTULAS THIS PACKAGE FITS

More than 900 species exist, and they do not share one set of numbers. This package is written for the beginner species: the ground-dwelling (terrestrial) Chilean rose hair, curly hair, Brazilian black, Chaco golden knee and Mexican red knee, and the tree-dwelling (arboreal) pink toe. Where a figure belongs to one species, the page names it. Deep burrowers and the faster, more defensive species from Africa and Asia are outside its scope.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An exotics vet who will see an invertebrate, where one exists. Many areas have none, which is why this book leans hard on prevention. Find out now whether anyone within reach will see a tarantula, and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Family	Theraphosidae, the tarantulas: more than 900 species, on every continent except Antarctica
Species in this package	Chilean rose hair, curly hair, Brazilian black, Chaco golden knee and Mexican red knee on the ground; the pink toe in the trees
Adult size	Up to about 6 in (15 cm) leg span for a female rose hair, about 6.5 in (17 cm) for a curly hair, about 5 in (13 cm) for a female pink toe. Across the whole family, 2 to 12 in (5 to 30 cm)
Lifespan	Set by sex and species. A female rose hair commonly 15 to 20 years or more; a male about 5, 10 at the outside
Diet type	Carnivore: live insects only, with no formulated diet (page 12)
Enclosure (terrestrial adult)	About 20×10×10 in (51×25×25 cm), roughly a 10-gallon tank, floor about 3× the leg span, under about 12 in (30 cm) tall
The one hard rule	Keep a ground-dweller low. Height is the risk, floor area is the benefit, and a fall can rupture the abdomen (page 6)
Housing	One per enclosure. Most species are solitary and cannibalistic, and no enclosure size fixes that
Handling	Look, don't touch. The risk runs in both directions (page 17)
Conservation	Varies by species. Some, the rose hair among them, are listed under CITES, the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora. Buy captive-bred

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$25 to \$100 for a beginner species, plus \$105 to \$305 for the setup, with every item priced: \$130 to \$405 all in. Every line is on page 34.

Ongoing

\$75 to \$235 a year, about \$5 to \$20 a month, most of it feeder insects, with gut-load food and fresh substrate the rest. No insurer covers a tarantula, and routine vet visits are not part of the budget.

THE REAL NUMBER TO SIT WITH

Not the money, the years. A female rose hair is a 15 to 20 year commitment on a budget most pets spend in a month, so the time is the thing to think through before you buy.

Fun facts worth knowing

- They digest food outside the body. Enzymes injected through the fangs liquefy the prey, a muscular sucking stomach pumps the meal in, and the empty shell is left behind as a small pellet.
- Females keep molting for life. Males stop at maturity, which is a large part of why a female can outlive a male by a decade or more.
- Their blood, called hemolymph, is not held in vessels. It flows freely around the organs, which is why a ruptured abdomen turns fatal so fast.

The species covered, size & lifespan

"Tarantula" covers animals with different needs. Know which one is in the enclosure.

Ask the seller for the species in Latin, and write it on the emergency card. It decides the enclosure, the humidity, the lifespan, and in one state whether you need a permit. New World tarantulas come from the Americas and defend themselves by flicking irritating hairs; every species below is one. Old World tarantulas, from Africa and Asia, are faster, more defensive and carry a stronger bite, and this package does not cover them.

SPECIES	LIVES	ADULT LEG SPAN	LIFESPAN AND NOTES
Chilean rose hair <i>Grammostola rosea</i>	On the ground	Up to about 6 in (15 cm)	Females 15 to 20 years or more; males about 5, 10 at the outside. Dry-adapted, and known for long fasts. Usually \$60 to \$70.
Curly hair <i>Tliltocatl albopilosus</i>	On the ground	About 6.5 in (17 cm)	Females 25 years or longer; males around 5. Usually \$30 to \$40.
Brazilian black <i>Grammostola pulchra</i>	On the ground	Not listed	The species in the one controlled housing study (page 19).
Chaco golden knee <i>Grammostola pulchripes</i>	On the ground	Not listed	With the rose hair and the Brazilian black, one of the three tarantulas Maine leaves unrestricted.
Mexican red knee <i>Brachypelma</i>	On the ground	Not listed	Females 25 to 30 years; males rarely past 10. Its genus is on CITES Appendix II.
Pink toe <i>Avicularia avicularia</i>	In trees and bushes	About 5 in (13 cm) for a female, 3.5 in (9 cm) for a male	About 4 to 8 years on average. Needs a tall enclosure and more airflow (page 7). Usually \$30 to \$40.

No adult size is listed for these species.

Lifespan: the sex decides it

Females keep molting their whole adult lives. Males stop at the molt that makes them mature, and most die within about a year of reaching maturity and mating. That is why two spiders of one species can differ by a decade or more. A male rose hair lives about 5 years in all; a female 15 to 20 or more. Slings are usually sold unsexed, so an unsexed spiderling is a coin flip on lifespan. How sexing works is on page 24.

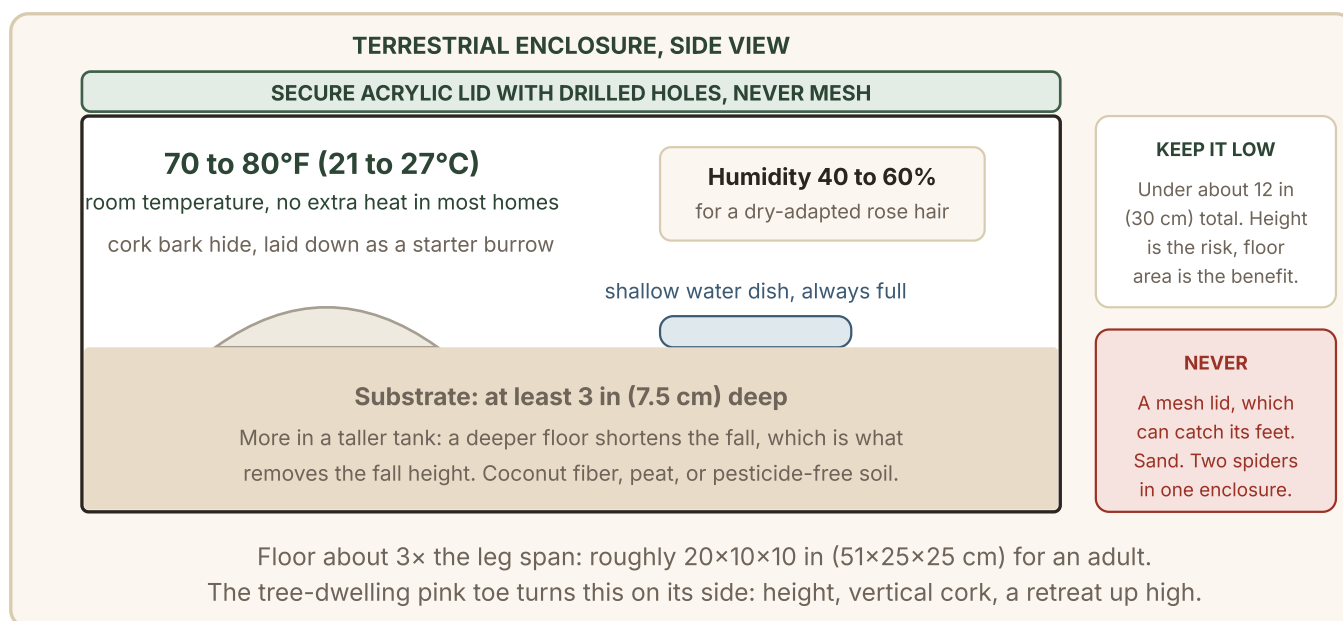
CITES AND BUYING CAPTIVE-BRED

CITES is the treaty that controls trade in listed animals between countries. The genera *Brachypelma*, *Tliltocatl* and *Poecilotheria* are on its Appendix II, and the Chilean rose hair joined them in March 2026. Buying captive-bred adds nothing to the capture of wild animals, and a captive-bred spider is less likely to carry parasites (page 20).

Enclosure shape, size & where it goes

Most pet tarantulas are terrestrial, and their enclosure is **horizontal, wider than it is tall**, to limit how far the spider can fall. A reasonable adult minimum is about 20×10×10 in (51×25×25 cm), roughly a 10-gallon tank, sized to about three times the leg span. An adult female rose hair spans up to about 6 in (15 cm) and a curly hair about 6.5 in (17 cm), which is why three times the leg span lands near that 20 in (51 cm) floor. Keep the overall height under about 12 in (30 cm).

The height rule is not fussiness. A short fall that most pets would shrug off can rupture a tarantula's abdomen and kill it, so everything about a terrestrial setup comes back to not letting the spider fall. Deep substrate is what takes the height away.



The lid

A secure lid, but never a mesh top: a tarantula's feet can catch in mesh and the spider can be badly hurt. Acrylic with drilled ventilation holes is the better choice. Holes must be small enough that the spider cannot fit through.

One spider per enclosure

Most species are solitary and cannibalistic. Cohabitation is not a workable setup at any enclosure size.

Where it goes

- Out of direct sun. Glass and acrylic heat fast, and the spider cannot leave.
- In a room that is never sprayed, fogged or treated for insects, with no plug-in insect devices (page 30).
- At ordinary room temperature, which suits most tarantulas with no added heat (page 8).
- Off the floor and somewhere you will look at it. Watching is most of the husbandry.

Arboreal enclosures & housing a sling

Two setups that break the low-and-wide rule: a tree-dweller, and a spider too small for any adult enclosure.

The pink toe, a tree-dweller

A pink toe lives in trees and bushes, and its enclosure turns the terrestrial rules on their side. An adult female Guyana pink toe grows to about 5 in (13 cm), and a male to about 3.5 in (9 cm). It gets a **taller** enclosure with vertical cork bark tubes and branches to anchor its silk retreat up high, since the height is for climbing.

Cross-ventilation	More important here than for any ground-dweller. Holes on opposite sides keep air moving through, because stagnant, humid air is what harms this species. Airflow comes first, ahead of any humidity number.
Humidity	About 65 to 80%, held by a shallow water dish and slightly moist lower layers of substrate.
Temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), the same as a terrestrial.
Moving it	Bring the cup to the spider at its own level on the decor, or move it already sealed in a container it has retreated into (page 21).

Housing a sling

A sling, or spiderling, never goes in the adult enclosure. A sling can be 1/4 in (0.6 cm) across the legs or less, small enough to vanish against the substrate, and in a big tank nobody can tell whether it is eating or molting.

Container	Small plastic vials, sized in drams, suit the tiniest slings. Deli cups are the usual home for any young tarantula: 16 ounces for a terrestrial sling, 32 ounces for an arboreal one. Ventilate with two or three rings of small holes, every hole smaller than the spider's carapace, the hard plate over the front of its body.
Substrate	For a terrestrial sling, fill at least two-thirds of the container with packed-down substrate, and push the back of a paintbrush in near the side for a starter burrow. Keep it on the dry side of damp: a container that is too moist and stuffy is a death trap for a sling.
Water	From about 1/2 in (1.3 cm) across, a sling gets a water dish whenever one fits, and the cap from a plastic water bottle is the usual first dish. Overflow it a little for a moist patch of substrate too. A sling too small for a dish drinks from a dampened corner.
Heat	Room temperature raises most slings, and many keepers hold them at 68 to 75°F (20 to 24°C) with no added heat. They do not need 80°F (27°C) or more.
Arboreal slings	The taller 32-ounce cup with about 1 in (2.5 cm) of substrate, and a piece of bark leaned at an angle against the side to climb and web against.

TWO SLING RULES

Never leave uneaten prey in overnight, since a cricket can attack and kill a molting sling. Guide a sling with a soft paintbrush, never by hand.

Temperature, heat & light

The easiest part of tarantula keeping, and the one most often overcomplicated.

Room temperature is the target

Room temperature, roughly 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), is fine for most homes with no supplemental heat, and most tarantulas stay comfortable anywhere from 70 to 85°F (21 to 29°C). There is no basking spot and no hot and cool end to build, as a reptile needs. Slings need no more than room temperature either (page 7).

READING	°F	°C
Target, adults and juveniles	70 to 80	21 to 27
Comfortable range	70 to 85	21 to 29
Slings, as many keepers hold them	68 to 75	20 to 24

If your home runs cold

Use a heat mat mounted on the **side** of the enclosure, never the bottom, and run it through a thermostat. A thermostat is a switch that holds the mat at a set temperature by reading a probe, a small sensor on a wire. Place the probe where your thermostat's manual says, hold it with a probe clip or a suction cup, never tape, and set the thermostat inside the range above. A heat source with no thermostat is one the spider cannot get away from.

Reading the numbers

A digital thermometer and hygrometer combination reads temperature and humidity at once, so you are reading numbers rather than guessing. Put it where the spider lives, low in the enclosure, and check it weekly.

Light

None is required. Most pet tarantulas are nocturnal, and bright light or direct sun is something to avoid rather than add. Ordinary room light on a normal day and night cycle is all they need. A tarantula has no use for the ultraviolet lamps a reptile depends on.

NEVER

A heat mat under the enclosure floor, a heat source with no thermostat, a probe taped in place, or an enclosure in a sunny window.

Humidity, water & ventilation

A full water dish does most of the work, and airflow keeps damp from turning into mold.

Humidity by species

SPECIES	TARGET
Rose hair and other dry-adapted ground-dwellers	40 to 60%. Ventilation matters more than the number, and stagnant damp breeds mold.
Pink toe	About 65 to 80%, with strong cross-ventilation (page 7).

The steadiest way to hold it is a reliable water dish plus lightly moistened substrate, with a fine mist spray used sparingly. Overflowing the dish to dampen one corner gives a moist patch the spider can choose. Heavy misting mostly adds mold, with no clear benefit.

The water dish

DEHYDRATION IS THE MOST COMMON HEALTH PROBLEM

Tarantulas survive long fasts but die quickly without water. A shallow dish, kept full, prevents most of it, for every species including the dry-adapted ones.

- **Shallow.** A deep dish can drown a tarantula. A bottle cap for a small spider; a shallow dish for an adult.
- **Changed daily.** Fresh water at all times. Substrate, silk and prey remains all end up in it.
- **No sponges.** A damp sponge breeds bacteria.
- **Buried dishes.** A spider that buries its dish is working the substrate. Dig it out, refill it, and leave the rest.
- **Slings** too small for a cap drink from a dampened corner of the substrate.

Ventilation

Airflow is the counterweight to humidity, and it is what keeps mold and mites down. Holes on opposite sides of the enclosure, not only in the lid, move air across it instead of letting it sit. Too much is a problem too: too much ventilation together with a missing water dish is the usual cause of dehydration. If a spider dries out, a little less airflow and a damp patch of substrate are part of the fix.

THE HABIT THAT PREVENTS MOST OF THIS BOOK

Look at the water dish every day and top it up. It takes seconds and prevents the leading cause of death in captive tarantulas.

Substrate, hides & furnishings

Deep enough to remove the fall height and hold a burrow, and furnished low.

Substrate

Coconut fiber, peat, or organic pesticide-free soil, or a mix. All three hold moisture well and support burrowing. Use at least 3 in (7.5 cm), and more in a taller tank, because a deeper floor is what takes away the fall height.

NEVER SAND

Sand is the one substrate to leave out of a tarantula enclosure.

Many wild ground-dwelling tarantulas spend much of their time in burrows they dig themselves or take over from other animals. Depth lets a pet express that instinct even though it will never need to escape a predator. Species that are obligate burrowers need far more depth than any spider in this package, which is one reason they are not covered here.

A retreat

Every tarantula wants somewhere to be out of sight. Cork bark, a half-log, or half of a terracotta pot all work. Lay cork down as a starter burrow for a terrestrial, or stand it upright for an arboreal species to web a tube against.

Let it remodel

A tarantula that rearranges its substrate, webs up the entrance to its hide, or buries its water dish is doing the closest thing to construction this animal does. Don't tidy it back. An enclosure it can't alter is one less thing for it to do.

Low structure

Cork flats, leaf litter, a low branch, moss or sphagnum, all anchored so nothing can shift onto the spider. Keep it low for terrestrial species: structure to move through, not to climb up and fall from.

TERRESTRIAL

Wide and low, substrate at least 3 in (7.5 cm) deep, cork laid flat. The rose hair, curly hair, Brazilian black, Chaco golden knee and red knee.

ARBOREAL

Tall, lower substrate kept slightly moist, vertical cork and branches, strong cross-ventilation. The pink toe.

Cleaning, hygiene & escapes

An enclosure that never looks dirty still needs a routine, and the usual mistake is cleaning too much.

TASK	HOW OFTEN	WHY
Uneaten live prey out	Within 24 hours	Crickets and roaches attack a molting or resting spider
Prey remains and droppings out	As seen, at least weekly	The food source for every mite and mold problem
Water dish refilled with fresh water	Daily, kept full	Stagnant water is where flies and mites start
Mold spot removed with the substrate under it	As seen	Caught early, a spoonful of substrate; late, the whole enclosure
Substrate replaced	Every 6 to 12 months in a damp setup, or at the first mold; a dry, well-ventilated one can run for years	Mold starts in damp, stale substrate
Full strip-down and disinfect	Only after mites on the spider, a nematode case, or a death	Otherwise a disturbance with no benefit

A tarantula can sit on the same substrate for years. Every problem in the enclosure comes down to prey remains and dampness without airflow: take the remains out, keep air moving, and neither mites nor mold take hold. Small flies over the enclosure mean something is rotting in there. Find the remains or the soaked corner, remove it, and the flies leave within a week. Time any substrate change away from a molt (page 22).

Hygiene for you

Wash your hands after any enclosure work, and keep them away from your face and eyes until you have. Never share tongs, dishes or other tools between a new arrival in quarantine and any other animal (page 20). Wear safety glasses for a full substrate change, when hair-laden substrate gets moved around (page 31).

Escapes

Prevention. A sturdy, sealed enclosure with a locking lid, and ventilation holes too small for the spider, which for a sling means smaller than you would think. Most escapes happen during care, with the lid set aside for a moment.

The search. Close the door of the room first, then search that room thoroughly before widening: low, under furniture and in corners, for a ground-dweller, and up the walls, curtains and shelves for a pink toe, which climbs.

Recapture is a clear cup set over the spider and a stiff card slid underneath, carried back upright. No hands, since a fall from waist height can rupture the abdomen.

Diet by age

Live insects, no formulated diet, and a schedule that matters much less than most keepers expect.

STAGE	FEEDING
Sling under about 2 in (5 cm)	Every 2 to 3 days, on pinhead crickets, fruit flies or other tiny prey no larger than the sling's own abdomen.
Juvenile about 2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm)	Every 4 to 7 days at the young end of this stage, stretching to every 7 to 14 days as it grows. Growth slows here, so treat the number as a starting point and adjust it on abdomen size and appetite (page 16).
Subadult and adult	Commonly every 1 to 2 weeks, but the real need depends on the species. An adult rose hair, a slow-metabolism species, may need only four or five crickets a month, while a fast-growing tropical species can eat several times a week.
Mature male	After his final molt, many eat markedly less or stop almost entirely, and some never eat again. A natural end-of-life pattern, not a health problem (page 24).
Before and after a molt	Take prey out well before a molt and offer none during it. Afterward, wait for the fangs to harden: 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults (page 23).

TWO RULES AT EVERY STAGE

Prey is never larger than the tarantula's own abdomen, and anything uneaten comes out within 24 hours. A live cricket left in the enclosure can injure a freshly molted spider that cannot yet defend itself.

How a tarantula eats

It injects digestive enzymes through its fangs to liquefy the prey's insides outside its own body. A muscular sucking stomach then pumps the liquid meal into the gut, and the empty exoskeleton is left behind as a small pellet called a bolus. Offer prey live and whole, never chopped, and lift the bolus out with tongs when you see it. A single cricket can take days to fully digest.

How to offer it

Release, don't present. Put the prey in and let the spider hunt it. The ambush is what the animal is built for, and it is free enrichment.

Vary the timing, and log it. Feed on an irregular schedule, and write down what went in and whether it was taken (page 40). In an animal that can fast for months, the log tells a normal fast from a decline.

Feeder insects & the never-feed list

Staples every feeding, extras for variety, rare treats, and the items that never go in.

PREY	TIER	NOTES
Crickets	STAPLE	The usual default: high protein, low fat, easy to digest, and sold in every size from pinhead up.
Dubia or discoid roaches	STAPLE	A good alternative, especially for larger spiders, because they are more nutrient-dense and digest more slowly. Crush the head first on larger roaches, which can bite.
Mealworms	EXTRA	Useful as variety rather than a whole diet.
Superworms	EXTRA	Crush the head first. They bite, and a loose superworm is a hazard to a molting spider.
Waxworms	TREAT	Fine occasionally. Too fatty for regular use.
Pinky mouse	NEVER	Not for any species in this package.
Wild-caught insects of any kind	NEVER	A pesticide and parasite risk that is not worth taking. Buy from a breeder or a pet store.
Fireflies	NEVER	Toxic to reptiles, and never worth testing on a spider.
Anything from a sprayed garden or lawn	NEVER	Insecticide residue on a feeder reaches the spider with the meal.
Processed human food	NEVER	Not part of a tarantula's diet in any form.
Prey larger than the abdomen	NEVER	The size rule overrides curiosity, at every age.

WHY WILD-CAUGHT IS OUT EVEN FROM CLEAN COUNTRYSIDE

A 2021 study by Brühl and colleagues trapped flying insects inside 21 nature conservation areas in Germany and found residues of 47 current-use pesticides, with each sample carrying 16.7 on average. Insects from protected land, not sprayed fields, still carried them.

THE 24-HOUR RULE, BECAUSE IT MATTERS

Anything not eaten within 24 hours comes out. Crickets and roaches will attack a spider that is molting or freshly molted and cannot defend itself. Keepers lose spiders to this every year, and a look in the enclosure the next day prevents it.

Gut-loading, not supplements

The page a reptile keeper expects to find here is about calcium powder. For a tarantula it is about the feeder's last meal.

No dusting

Skip calcium and vitamin dusting entirely. That is a reptile practice, built for animals with bones, and a tarantula has none. Dusting has no place in a tarantula enclosure: it is linked to bad molts and gives the spider nothing it can use.

Gut-loading is the only route in

Gut-loading means feeding the feeder insects a nutritious diet for a day or two before they are offered, so that the nutrition reaches the spider. Whatever the cricket or roach has eaten is the whole nutritional content of the meal, which makes gut-loading the one lever a keeper has.

FEED THE FEEDERS	NOTES
Collard, mustard, turnip and dandelion greens	Calcium-dense and low in the compounds that block calcium
Butternut squash	Same group as the greens above
A dry diet sold on its calcium content	Look at the stated calcium, not a label that just says gut-load
Carrot and potato	Keep insects alive and hydrated, but add little else
Spinach, beet greens and Swiss chard	Skip them: high in oxalic acid, which binds calcium so it can't be absorbed

Timing

Insects start emptying their gut once they are taken off the food. A cricket left in an empty container for a day has already lost much of what you fed it, so offer feeders within a few hours of taking them off the gut-load. If you keep a standing tub of crickets or a roach colony, leave the gut-load food in all the time.

Where the feeders come from

Commercially farmed feeders from a breeder or pet store only. A cricket from the garden can carry pesticide or parasites into an animal that has no way to deal with either (page 13).

IN SHORT

No powder, ever. Feed the feeders well for a day or two, offer them within hours, and buy them farmed.

Why a tarantula stops eating

The one pet where skipping meals for weeks is normal. Here is how to tell a healthy fast from a sick spider.

1. **Premolt fasting.** By far the most common reason. A darkening, plumping abdomen and reduced activity come first. Slings might fast a few weeks, adults several months (page 22).
2. **Post-molt recovery.** The new exoskeleton and fangs are soft: no food for 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults.
3. **A mature male.** After his final molt, many males eat little or nothing as they focus on finding a mate.
4. **A new enclosure or stress.** A rehouse, a move, or a husbandry detail that is off (temperature, humidity, no hide) can put a spider off food for a stretch.
5. **The species.** Rose hairs are known for long, seemingly unprompted fasts.
6. **Prey pickiness.** Refusing one prey type, or prey that is too large, is not a health concern by itself.
7. **Illness, injury or dehydration.** The one that matters. Appetite loss with not drinking, a visible injury, uncoordinated legs, or legs curled tightly under an upright body points to a real problem (page 26).

An older spider refusing food with no premolt signs

Most of these spiders are healthy: a tarantula can go months without eating and stay well. Water is what kills quickly, so check in this order:

1. The abdomen	Plump and round means reserves and time. Shrunken or wrinkled means dehydration, and water comes before anything else (page 27).
2. The water dish	Full, clean, and shallow enough to reach. A spider seen drinking is not in trouble from the fast.
3. The mouth	White material around the mouthparts, with the appetite falling away, is the sign of oral nematodes (page 29).
4. The sex	A male just through his final molt often eats little or nothing from then on, and that is normal for him.
5. Recent changes	A rehouse, a move or a new room explains weeks of refusal on its own.

If all five come back clean, keep the water dish full, offer one prey item every week or two, and take it out within 24 hours when it is ignored. Log each offer. A fast that ends in a molt shows plainly in the log, and so does a spider losing condition.

WHEN TO WORRY

A juvenile refusing food for more than 6 to 8 weeks with weight loss or lethargy is worth a vet consult. Adults can safely fast for weeks to several months. At any age, refusal together with a shriveled abdomen, uncoordinated legs or a body it cannot lift is the emergency, and it can kill within days.

Body condition & growth

The abdomen is the gauge, and the molt is where growth happens.

Reading the abdomen

Look at the abdomen from above, and let it adjust the feeding schedule.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
Round and full	Fed. Keep the schedule, or stretch it. A fat tarantula's real danger is its abdomen rupturing in a fall
Plump, darkening, with a bald patch on top	Premolt: stop offering food (page 22)
Shrunken and wrinkled	Dehydration, not hunger: water first, today

Photograph the abdomen from above while the spider is healthy, and keep the picture with the log. A spider that is already round gets fewer meals, not more.

Growth happens at the molt

An exoskeleton cannot stretch, so a tarantula grows only by shedding the whole thing and hardening a larger one. Growth comes in steps, one per molt, and the steps space out with age.

STAGE	HOW OFTEN IT MOLTS
Slings and juveniles	Every few weeks to a couple of months
Mature adult	About once a year
Very old females	Some go several years between molts
Mature males	Never again after the molt that makes them mature

Measuring and logging

Leg span is the standard measure: diagonally from the tip of a front leg to the tip of the opposite back leg. Never handle the spider to measure it. Log each molt date and the size you can see, and keep the shed skin, which is also how a spider is sexed (page 24). Over a female's life, that molt log becomes the record of the animal.

Handling: why the answer is no

If you want a pet you can hold, a tarantula is the wrong choice, and it is better to know that before buying one than after.

The risk to the spider

A fall from your hand, your shoulder or a couch cushion can fatally injure a tarantula. Even a short drop, the kind that would not worry you with almost any other pet, can rupture the abdomen, and the hemolymph inside is not held in vessels, so the damage does not stay local. There is no margin for error, which is the same reason the enclosure is built low and wide.

The risk to you

New World species, every one in this package, defend themselves by flicking urticating hairs: tiny barbed hairs that irritate skin, airways and eyes. Bites are uncommon and rarely medically serious, roughly a hornet sting. The bigger problem is what follows a bite: the handler jerks or drops the spider, which brings back the fall risk, and the spider that was only defending itself often dies. Hairs in an eye, not bites, are the more common real injury in this hobby (page 31).

What interacting looks like instead

- Watching. A tarantula remodeling its burrow or taking prey is the point of keeping one.
- Long tongs for rearranging decor and lifting out a bolus or a shed skin.
- A catch cup and a stiff card for every move, low over a lined tub, with tongs or a soft paintbrush to steer the spider into the cup (page 21).
- Enclosure maintenance done without touching the spider at all.
- Washing your hands after any enclosure work, and keeping them away from your face and eyes until you have.

NEVER HANDLE

A tarantula in premolt, mid-molt or freshly molted, when its new exoskeleton is soft. Disturbing, handling or feeding it in that window is one of the few absolute rules in tarantula keeping (page 23).

THE HONEST TAKEAWAY

A tarantula is a rewarding animal to watch and a poor animal to hold. Handling adds risk for the spider and for you and gives the spider nothing it wants. Nobody should buy a tarantula with the goal of handling it.

Body language & normal behavior

Half of tarantula keeping is knowing which alarming-looking things are completely normal.

Defensive signals

Rearing up on the hind legs, flicking hairs toward a perceived threat, and displaying the fangs are all defensive signals. None of them means aggression the way that word works with a mammal. They are the responses of an animal that would much rather be left alone, and the right answer to every one of them is to close the enclosure and come back later. Never lean over a spider that is already kicking hairs.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS
Sitting motionless for days	Normal. In the one controlled housing study, inactivity was nearly all of the observed behavior.
Hiding all day, active after dark	Normal. Most pet tarantulas are nocturnal.
Rearranging substrate, webbing over the hide entrance, burying the water dish	Normal. The spider is building. Dig out and refill the dish, and leave the rest.
Refusing food, abdomen dark and swollen, a bald patch on top	Premolt. Stop offering food (page 22).
Lying on its back, legs folded over	Most likely molting. Leave it completely alone.
Legs curled tightly under an upright body	The death curl, a sign of serious dehydration. An emergency (page 27).
Front of the body lowered into the water dish for a long time	Drinking. A dehydrated spider can drink for minutes or hours.
A male with swollen tips on its palps (the short feelers beside the fangs), wandering, off food	A mature male after his final molt. Normal for him (page 24).
Jerky, uncoordinated or twitching legs	Not normal. Possible pesticide exposure or dyskinetic syndrome (page 30).

A spider on its back is not dying

A tarantula often molts on its back. A spider lying upside down with its legs folded is almost certainly mid-molt and must be left alone. The posture that looks similar and means the opposite is the death curl, where the legs curl tightly underneath an upright body. Learn to tell those two apart before you ever need to.

Don't read stillness as anything at all

A still spider looks the same whether the setup is right or wrong. Judge the husbandry on substrate, humidity, ventilation and water rather than on how busy the animal looks.

Enrichment & common mistakes

There is exactly one controlled tarantula housing study, and it found less than enthusiasts hope and more than skeptics expect.

Stalter, Dorleus, Milone, Sincage, Skurski and Leeds published a preliminary study of Brazilian black tarantulas in December 2024. They compared Standard housing against Complex housing, which was about six times larger with six times as many structural elements. All four findings belong together:

Activity	Did not change. Inactivity was nearly all of the observed behavior in both enclosures.
Space use	Did change. Home ranges were 77% larger and core areas 113% larger in the complex enclosure.
Boldness	In a new environment, spiders from the complex enclosure had 150% greater odds of being active.
Preference	None. Offered both at once, the spiders split their time roughly evenly.

The authors concluded that complexity may improve welfare, while noting the small sample. Go larger than the minimum floor where you sensibly can, with two limits: never add fall height for a ground-dweller, and don't make the enclosure so large that a small spider is hard to find and feed.

Priority order

1. Substrate depth and enclosure type matched to the species

2. Water, always available

3. A retreat the spider can web into and modify
4. Correct humidity and ventilation

5. Floor area beyond the minimum, without fall height

6. Low structure to move through

7. Live prey released, at varied times

Common mistakes

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS
Letting the water dish run dry	Dehydration, the most common health problem and the easiest to avoid
A tall enclosure, or one only part-filled, for a ground-dweller	Fall height, and a ruptured abdomen
A mesh lid on the adult enclosure	Feet catch in it and the spider can be badly hurt
A burrowing species on shallow substrate, for the view	The most common genuine welfare failure in tarantula keeping
Leaving uneaten prey in overnight	Crickets and roaches attack a molting spider
Feeding, moving or handling around a molt	Interrupting a molt can kill
Reading a fast as illness, or stillness as a problem	Weeks without food and days without moving are both normal
A heat mat under the floor, or heavy misting	Overheating from below; mold and mites from standing damp
Two spiders in one enclosure	Most species are solitary and cannibalistic
Bug spray, foggers or flea treatment in the same room	A healthy spider can die overnight with no warning (page 30)

Choosing a spider, quarantine & finding a vet

Buy captive-bred, look at the abdomen and the mouth, and keep it apart until it has settled.

Choosing a seller

Buy captive-bred. Captive-bred spiders are less likely to carry oral nematodes, the parasite that turns up mostly in wild-caught imports, and buying them adds nothing to the capture of wild animals.

Choosing the spider

Look for a plump abdomen, and the species name in Latin on the label or the receipt. A "sexed female" should come with a photo of the molt she was sexed from (page 24).

Walk away from a shrunken, wrinkled abdomen, which means dehydration and is common in spiders kept badly in shops, and from any white material around the mouth, the nematode sign.

Quarantine: until it has settled

A new tarantula lives apart from any other invertebrate, ideally in a different room, with its own tools: not the tongs, not the water dish, not your hands between enclosures without washing. No veterinary source puts a number of weeks on it, so watching sets the length: keep it apart until it has been seen to feed, drink and settle, and longer if it was wild-caught. The problems that arrive with a new spider are slow. Mites build over weeks, mold takes hold in a damp corner, and nematodes turn up mostly in wild-caught imports.

Use a plain enclosure with paper towel or bare substrate, a water dish and a hide. Feed lightly, leave a molt alone if one comes, and look at the spider, the substrate and the prey remains every few days. A first and only spider still gets the weeks of watching: it is the window in which a problem shows up while the setup is simple enough to see it. For a shipped spider, the first days are about a dark, quiet enclosure with water, not food.

Finding a vet before you need one

There is no routine first vet visit for a tarantula, and many areas have no vet who treats invertebrates at all. Search now for an exotics vet who will see one, ask whether they do, and write the number on the emergency card. Where none exists, experienced keepers are the realistic second line, though they are not a diagnosis. What a vet will want to hear is on page 26.

Rehousing: the cup and card method

Moving a spider is two jobs: everything ready before the lid comes off, then a slow, low transfer with no hands.

When

When the spider outgrows its container, when a sling moves up a size, when a shipped spider comes out of its cup, or when quarantine ends. **Never** in premolt, mid-molt or freshly molted, whatever the reason (page 23).

Before the lid comes off

- ☐ New enclosure set up and running a few hours ahead: substrate in, decor placed, water dish filled
- ☐ Door shut, gaps under furniture checked, drawers and floor vents covered
- ☐ Pets and children out of the room
- ☐ Catch cup, a spare cup, and a stiff card or thin rigid plastic within reach
- ☐ A large lined tub, or a bathtub for big spiders, under the whole job
- ☐ Safety glasses on, room ventilated, face out of the enclosure

The method

1. Lower a clear, smooth-sided cup over the spider, with room for it to stand normally.
2. Slide the card along the surface under the cup until it seals the opening.
3. Lift cup and card together as one sealed unit, keeping the card pressed flat.
4. Carry it low and level to the new enclosure, set it down inside, slide the card back and lift the cup away. Let the spider walk out on its own; never tip or shake it out.

Work a few inches above the tub floor, not a few feet above open floor. That height is the single biggest thing you control. For a pink toe, bring the cup to the spider at its own level on the decor, or move it already sealed in a container it has retreated into. Steer a sling with a soft paintbrush.

If it bolts

- Don't grab it. A reflexive grab is how a keeper ends up with a fall, a bite or a face full of hairs.
- Stay still and let it run. Most stop once they reach cover or a corner.
- The tub is why it has a floor and not a fall. Re-approach slowly, cup first.
- If it gets out of the tub, dim the lights, close the door, and give it a few minutes to settle before trying again (page 11).

Molting: the cycle

A tarantula grows by shedding its whole exoskeleton. It is the most vulnerable thing that happens to it, and it happens over and over.

What is going on

An exoskeleton does not stretch. To grow, the spider builds a new, larger one underneath, sheds the entire old one, including the linings of parts such as the fangs and the book lungs, the breathing organs under the abdomen, and then hardens the new one. The shed skin left behind, the exuvia, is a hollow copy of the animal, and it is how a spider is sexed (page 24).

Reading premolt

SIGN	WHAT IT MEANS
Refusing food, sometimes for weeks or months	Normal and expected. Stop offering food rather than persisting.
Abdomen dark and swollen	The new exoskeleton forming beneath the old one.
A bald patch on top of the abdomen	Hairs kicked off. A clear early sign.
Reduced movement, a dulled look	Normal. Leave it be.
Heavy webbing, a silk mat, or sealing itself in	Preparation. Leave the web exactly as it is.

How long it takes

PREMOLT

A few weeks of fasting for a sling, several months for an adult. There is no way to hurry it.

THE MOLT ITSELF

15 minutes to several hours, often on its back. A long, quiet stretch inside that window is normal.

HARDENING

3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults, before the fangs are hard enough to eat with.

How often

Juveniles molt every few weeks to a couple of months. A mature adult may molt once a year, and very old females of some species go several years between molts. Females keep molting for life. A male stops for good at the molt that makes him mature, which is why he lives so much shorter than she does.

LOG THE CYCLE

Note the date you first see premolt signs, the molt date, and the date it ate again (page 41). After two or three cycles the next one becomes predictable, and a fast stops being a worry.

Molting: what to do and never do

THE ONE ABSOLUTE RULE IN TARANTULA KEEPING

Do not handle, disturb, move or feed a tarantula in premolt, mid-molt, or while the new exoskeleton hardens. Not to check on it, not to rearrange the enclosure, not for a better photo. Physical disturbance during or just after a molt is one of the most common preventable causes of death.

During premolt: do

- Take out any prey already in the enclosure, well before the molt.
- Keep the water dish full.
- Keep humidity in the species' range. Too little humidity in premolt is linked to failed molts.
- Leave the webbing as the spider built it.

During premolt: don't

- Don't rehouse. If the enclosure needs changing, wait until the spider has hardened.
- Don't keep offering food because it has been a while.
- Don't mist the spider directly.
- Don't "help" by pulling at the old skin.

After the molt

- Leave it alone for the hardening window: 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults. The fangs are soft, and it cannot eat or defend itself.
- Keep the water dish full throughout.
- At the end of the window, offer one prey item. If it is refused, take it out within 24 hours and try again in a few days.
- Lift the shed skin out with tongs once the spider has moved away from it, and keep it for sexing.
- Log the molt date.

Slow is not the same as stuck

NORMAL	STUCK
A molt that takes several hours, with long quiet stretches	Half in and half out of the old skin for hours with no progress
A pale, soft spider lying still after it climbs out	Struggling that goes nowhere, or legs left twisted at the end

WHEN A MOLT GOES WRONG

Call an experienced keeper or an exotics vet. Never try to pull the old skin off yourself, which tears limbs. A failed molt is far less common than a normal one, and most trace back to low humidity in premolt, disturbance, or an underlying health problem (page 28).

Sexing, mature males & eggs

The sex decides how long you have this animal: a female rose hair can outlive a male by a decade or more.

The mature male

Young males and females look almost identical. The difference shows when a male makes his final molt: he grows bulbs on the tips of his palps (the pair of short, leg-like feelers beside the fangs) and, in many species, hooks under the first pair of legs. A spider already showing those is a mature male with a short time left. Many stop eating, and most die within about a year of reaching maturity and mating. That is natural, not illness.

Sexing from the shed skin

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS AND HOW FAR TO TRUST IT
The shed skin	The best method. A female sheds the lining of her spermathecae, the sperm-storage organs, with the rest of the exoskeleton. Opened out and laid flat, the abdomen of her molt shows them as a flap between the book lungs, just above the furrow that crosses the underside; a male's molt has no flap there. A small molt can need a magnifying glass, a close-up photo or a microscope, and on a well-grown female's molt the flap is plain to the naked eye. Soften the molt with a little water before opening it out.
The live spider's underside	The backup, and often wrong. Trust a molt over it.
Mature male features	Conclusive, but late: the palp bulbs and leg hooks appear only at the final molt.

What that means when you buy

- **Unsexed slings** are the cheapest route, and any one of them may turn out male.
- A **"sexed female"** should come with a photo of the molt she was sexed from. A guess from the underside or from body shape is not the same product.
- **Sexing your own later** is free: keep each molt, soften it, and have it checked.

Eggs

A mated female lays her eggs, sometimes hundreds at once, sealed inside a silk egg sac, and gives no care once the spiderlings emerge and disperse. Breeding is outside the scope of this package, which is written for one spider kept alone.

Is a tarantula legal where you live?

Legal with no permit in most of the United States, because most wildlife laws stop at animals with backbones.

This page covers all 50 states, the District of Columbia and New York City, which has its own rules: 52 jurisdictions. A pet tarantula is **legal with no permit in 41, barred in 4, permit-only in 1, limited to named species in 1, legal on a condition in 1, and unclear in 4**. Most state wildlife codes stop at mammals, birds, fish, reptiles and amphibians, so a spider is invisible to them.

WHERE	STATUS	THE RULE
New York City	Barred	Health Code § 161.01(b)(13) names the tarantula outright among "venomous spiders." A city rule, so it applies whatever New York State allows.
Hawaii	Barred	No tarantula appears on any of the four lists (Hawaii Revised Statutes § 150A-6.2(c)), and anything unlisted is prohibited by default.
Montana	Barred	A white-list state (Montana Code § 87-5-705(1)). Its arachnid rule clears two scorpions and no spiders, so the tarantula is barred by omission.
District of Columbia	Barred	District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j)(1) allows seven listed groups, none of them invertebrate.
Rhode Island	Permit	The invertebrate exemption (Rhode Island Code of Regulations 250-RICR-40-05-3, § 3.8(G)) covers only the class Insecta, and spiders are not insects.
Maine	Three species	The Unrestricted Species List clears only the Brazilian black, Chaco golden knee and Chilean rose. Every other tarantula, the curly hair and pink toe included, needs a permit.
Oregon	Conditional	Cleared at family level by the Department of Agriculture (Oregon Administrative Rules 603-052-1320), but only for stock collected within the continental United States. An import from abroad needs a Department permit.
Idaho, Arkansas, New Mexico, New Jersey	Unclear	Each state's wording arguably reaches an invertebrate but was plainly not written with one in mind. Ask the state wildlife agency in writing and keep the reply.

Legal with no permit: 41 jurisdictions

Alabama, Alaska, Arizona, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, Florida, Georgia, Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maryland, Massachusetts, Michigan, Minnesota, Mississippi, Missouri, Nebraska, Nevada, New Hampshire, New York State, North Carolina, North Dakota, Ohio, Oklahoma, Pennsylvania, South Carolina, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Vermont, Virginia, Washington, West Virginia, Wisconsin and Wyoming.

In nine of them, California, Illinois, Kentucky, Maryland, Michigan, Nevada, North Carolina, Ohio and Washington, the state lets cities or counties be stricter, and Oregon does the same. Check your local ordinance (a city or county law) and your lease too.

BEYOND STATE LAW

CITES controls trade in listed species between countries; the Chilean rose hair and every *Brachypelma* are on its Appendix II. Buying captive-bred from a domestic breeder keeps you clear of that. Shipping has its own rules (page 38).

NOT LEGAL ADVICE

State legal status as of October 2026. This is a summary of state rules, read on 1 October 2026 (Maine on 5 August 2026), and not legal advice. Rules change. Before you buy or move, check with your state wildlife agency and with your city or county.

Red flags & finding a vet

Veterinary care for tarantulas is limited, so prevention does most of the work and knowing what is normal matters most.

ACT TODAY IF YOU SEE

A shriveled, wrinkled abdomen with lethargy · legs curled tightly under an upright body · a spider that cannot lift its body off the ground · clear fluid leaking from the abdomen or a joint, or a split abdomen · a molt stuck half on for hours with no progress · jerky, uncoordinated or twitching legs · white material around the mouthparts · fuzzy mold growing on the spider itself · mites clustered on the spider · a juvenile off food more than 6 to 8 weeks with weight loss or lethargy. Check the water dish and humidity first, every time.

What to have ready for a vet or an experienced keeper

- ☐ The species in Latin, and the spider's sex if known
- ☐ The last molt date, and whether premolt signs came before this
- ☐ What it last ate and when, from the Owner Log
- ☐ Measured temperature and humidity, and the substrate
- ☐ When the signs started, and anything that changed: a rehouse, a move, a spray used nearby
- ☐ Clear photos of the spider from above and of anything unusual

Finding a vet

Many areas have no vet who treats invertebrates, so look before the first problem. Search for exotics practices, ask each one whether it sees tarantulas, and write the number on the emergency card (page 33). Where no vet will, experienced keepers are the realistic second line. They are useful, but they are not a diagnosis. Treatment options for a tarantula are limited even with a vet, which is why the habits in this book carry so much weight.

Normal or concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Weeks or months without food with a plump abdomen, often before a molt	Refusing food with a shrunken, wrinkled abdomen at any age
Sitting still for days	Unable to lift the body, or legs curled tightly underneath it
Lying on its back with legs folded, mid-molt	Half out of the old skin for hours with no progress
A bald patch on the abdomen before a molt	Clear fluid on the abdomen or at a joint
Heavy webbing, sealing itself in, a buried water dish	Twitching or uncoordinated legs

THE DISTINCTION THAT DOES THE WORK

A plump spider refusing food is almost always fine. A shriveled spider refusing food is an emergency. In this animal, hydration is the red flag, not hunger. Look at the abdomen before you look at the calendar.

Dehydration & reading the abdomen

The most common health problem in pet tarantulas, and almost always preventable with a dish of water.

Causes	A missing or empty water dish, usually together with too much ventilation. A spider that has stopped eating also loses the water its prey carried. Tarantulas survive long fasts but die quickly without water.
Signs	A shriveled, wrinkled, raisin-like abdomen; lethargy beyond the normal stillness; legs curling tightly underneath the body, sometimes called the death curl; and at the end, a spider that cannot lift its body off the ground. It can be fatal within days.
The fix	A shallow, open dish of water straight away, where the spider can reach it. A dehydrated spider lowers the front of its body into the water and drinks for minutes or even hours. The abdomen starts to fill out within a few hours, and activity usually picks up overnight.
Afterward	Cut back the ventilation a little and keep part of the substrate damp, so it cannot happen again. Mild cases often resolve once conditions are corrected.

Reading the abdomen

The abdomen is the fuel gauge for water and food at once. Learn what your spider's looks like when it is well, and photograph it.

ABDOMEN	WHAT IT MEANS
Plump, smooth and round	Fed and hydrated. A round spider gets fewer meals, not more (page 16).
Plump, darkening, with a bald patch on top	Premolt. Normal. Stop offering food.
Shrunken, wrinkled, obviously undersized	Dehydration. Water now.
Shriveled, with legs curling beneath the body	Advanced dehydration. Water now, and treat it as an emergency.

TWO POSTURES NOT TO CONFUSE

Upside down with legs folded over is a spider molting: leave it alone. Upright with legs curled tightly underneath is the death curl: water immediately.

PREVENTION IS ONE HABIT

A shallow dish, kept full, changed daily, for every spider of every species, plus humidity in its range (page 9). When a tarantula stops eating, check the water first.

Falls, injuries & stuck molts

The two physical emergencies, both mostly prevented by not touching the spider.

Falls and trauma

Why it's serious	The abdomen is covered by a thin cuticle with none of the reinforcement of the legs or front body. Hemolymph, the tarantula equivalent of blood, is not held in vessels; it flows freely through the body cavity and bathes the organs, so even a moderate rupture can turn fatal quickly.
Signs	A split or dented abdomen, or clear hemolymph leaking from a wound or a joint.
Response	A ruptured abdomen or a visible leak is a real emergency. A minor leak can sometimes be stemmed with a small amount of cornstarch applied to the wound. Anything beyond minor bleeding needs specialist attention if you can find it, and how fast you act often decides the outcome.
Where falls happen	Mostly during attempted handling, and during rushed rehousing or a slide inside a car. A fall from waist height can rupture the abdomen.

Stuck and failed molts

A stuck or incomplete molt can be fatal, and prevention matters more than any response: humidity in the species' range through premolt, and no disturbing or feeding during the molt. The molt itself runs anywhere from 15 minutes to several hours, and a long, quiet stretch inside that window is normal.

Stuck looks like	A spider half in and half out of the old skin for hours with no progress, struggling that goes nowhere, or legs left twisted at the end.
Response	Call an experienced keeper or an exotics vet. Never pull at the old skin yourself; an untrained attempt to help is how a survivable molt becomes a fatal one.
Usual causes	Too little humidity in premolt, physical disturbance, or an underlying health problem.

AFTER ANY INJURY

Keep the water dish full and within easy reach, keep the enclosure quiet, and take out any live prey. A spider that cannot defend itself is a target for a cricket.

THE PREVENTION IS TWO SENTENCES LONG

Keep a ground-dweller's enclosure low and mostly full of substrate, so there is nothing to fall from. Don't handle the spider, and move it only with a cup and card, low over a tub (page 21).

Oral nematodes, mites & mold

One serious parasite, and two problems that are mostly about cleaning and airflow.

Oral nematodes

Parasitic nematodes are microscopic worms that infect a tarantula's mouth, and they are one of the common reasons a pet spider sees a vet. Captive-bred spiders are less likely to carry them. The signs:

- White material around the mouthparts, the clearest sign
- Loss of appetite
- Lethargy beyond the normal stillness

Isolate the spider from any others at once, with its own tools, and contact an exotics vet if one can be found. A vet can remove the worms under anesthesia, sometimes over several sessions, but once an infection has taken hold no treatment has been documented to cure it. If the spider has to be euthanized, that is a vet's job, with an anesthetic overdose; a freezer on its own is not humane. That is why captive-bred spiders and quarantine matter (page 20).

Mites

Most mites in an enclosure are harmless scavengers living on prey remains, and the fix is removing the remains and restoring ventilation. The ones that matter are on the spider itself. That calls for a vet with invertebrate experience, never a chemical. Nearly every product sold to kill mites kills the spider too.

Mold

In the enclosure	Fuzzy growth on the substrate, on leftover prey, or in a damp corner. A husbandry problem: remove it with the substrate under it, cut back the misting, and improve airflow. Replace substrate that keeps molding.
On the spider	More serious. Fuzzy growth on the spider itself. Substrate kept too wet leads to fungal disease, and it hits spiders kept damp with poor airflow.
Response	Caught early: move the spider into a clean, dry, well-ventilated container with a water dish, away from the spores, and contact an exotics vet if one can be found.

SMALL FLIES ARE A CLUE

Flies hovering over the enclosure mean something is rotting in it. Find the prey remains or the soaked corner, remove it, and the flies leave within a week.

Dyskinetic syndrome & pesticides

A poorly understood condition, and the household hazard that can kill a well-kept spider overnight.

What DKS is

Dyskinetic syndrome (DKS) is a poorly understood loss of motor coordination. It is often fatal, and there is no well-established treatment. Its signs, jerky or uncoordinated movement and tremoring legs, are also the signs of pesticide poisoning, so the first job is ruling out a pesticide source.

Why insecticide reaches a spider

A tarantula is an arthropod, and every insecticide sold for home use is built to kill arthropods. The safety comparison on the labels is insects against people and pets, and a tarantula is on the wrong side of that line. No dose has been shown safe for a tarantula: these products act on insect nerves, and a spider's nerves are the same kind. A spider's book lungs draw air straight from the room, and a lid does not keep fumes out.

HOUSEHOLD ROUTE	WHY IT MATTERS
Aerosol bug sprays	Drift and settling residue reach an enclosure even from the next room.
Total release foggers (bug bombs)	Built to fill a whole room's air with insecticide. The worst of all.
Plug-in insect devices	Release insecticide into the room's air for days or weeks.
Flea and tick treatment on a dog or cat	Can transfer to fur and furniture in the same room, especially before a spot-on dries.
Ant and roach baits, pest control visits	Drawn from the same insecticide classes.
Wild-caught feeders	Insects from the outdoors can carry many residues (page 13).

If exposure happens

- Move the spider and its enclosure away from the source at once, to a room with a door that closes, and open the windows.
- Don't add water, dust or anything else to the enclosure to neutralize residue; no safe method is known.
- Watch for uncoordinated movement, tremoring legs, an unusual posture, or no response to vibration.
- Call an exotics vet if one is available, knowing the options are very limited.

PREVENTION IS THE ONLY PART THAT WORKS

Keep the enclosure in a room that is never sprayed, fogged or baited, with no plug-ins. Tell every pest control company in advance that you keep invertebrates, and ask for that room to be skipped. Treat dogs and cats for fleas in another room, and let spot-ons dry fully first. Move the spider out of the building for any building-wide treatment.

Urticating hairs, bites & your own safety

The most common real injury in tarantula keeping is not a bite. It is hairs in an eye.

Urticating hairs are tiny barbed hairs on the abdomen that a New World tarantula kicks off with its hind legs toward a threat. A rehouse is a common trigger, which is exactly when a keeper's face is closest. In a 2012 case report, Mangat and Newman showed under an electron microscope why these hairs are dangerous in an eye: they are barbed, so they migrate through the cornea and, in some cases, into the eye itself. Another published case, a keeper with a hair lodged deep in his cornea, needed steroid eye drops for nine months to control the inflammation, and recovered full vision.

WHERE	WHAT TO DO
Skin	Press tape onto the skin and lift it away, repeating until most of the hairs are out. Don't rub or scratch. If irritation continues or spreads, see a doctor.
Eyes	Do not rub. Cover the eye if you can without pressing on it, and get to an eye doctor or an emergency department the same day. No rinse is documented for an embedded hair, and early removal lowers the risk of lasting inflammation.
Airway	Wheezing, throat tightness or real difficulty breathing after hair exposure is a same-day emergency room visit. Severe cases have needed airway management.

Bites

Bites are uncommon and rarely medically serious, roughly a hornet sting. There is no antidote, and the venom of the New World species in this package typically causes only pain at the bite.

- Put the spider down on a low surface before reacting. The reflexive drop kills more spiders than bites hurt people.
- Wash the bite well with soap and water.
- A cool compress and an over-the-counter pain reliever such as acetaminophen or ibuprofen manage the pain.
- Check that the bitten person's tetanus shot is current.
- A poison center can advise on any bite: 1-800-222-1222 in the United States.
- Have the species name ready: "a tarantula" is not enough for a clinician.

PROTECT YOUR EYES, EVERY TIME

Keep your face out of the open enclosure, and never lean over a spider that is already kicking hairs. Wear safety glasses for rehousing and full substrate changes, when hair-laden substrate and old molts get moved around. A dust mask is a sensible addition for anyone rehousing New World species regularly, with the room ventilated.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Terrestrial: horizontal enclosure, about 20×10×10 in (51×25×25 cm), floor about 3× the leg span (page 6)
- ☐ Total height under about 12 in (30 cm) for a ground-dweller
- ☐ Pink toe: a taller enclosure with vertical cork and cross-ventilation (page 7)
- ☐ Secure acrylic lid with drilled holes, never mesh
- ☐ Coconut fiber, peat or pesticide-free soil, never sand (page 10)
- ☐ At least 3 in (7.5 cm) of substrate, more in a taller tank
- ☐ Cork bark, a half-log or half a terracotta pot as a hide
- ☐ Shallow water dish, and a spare (page 9)
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer, low in the enclosure
- ☐ Long feeding tongs, a catch cup, a spare cup and a stiff card
- ☐ A farmed feeder supply and gut-load food (page 14)
- ☐ Safety glasses, for rehousing and substrate changes

Targets

TARGET	FIGURE
Temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C); comfortable to 85°F (29°C)
Slings	Room temperature, 68 to 75°F (20 to 24°C) as many keepers hold them, no added heat
Humidity	40 to 60% for a rose hair and other dry-adapted species; about 65 to 80% for a pink toe
Substrate depth	3 in (7.5 cm) minimum, more in a taller tank
Prey size	No larger than the tarantula's own abdomen
Uneaten prey	Out within 24 hours, every time
Feeding	Slings every 2 to 3 days; juveniles every 4 to 7 days, then 7 to 14; adults every 1 to 2 weeks; none in premolt
Post-molt wait	3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults
Quarantine	Apart, with its own tools, until it has fed, drunk and settled
Substrate change	Every 6 to 12 months in a damp setup, or at the first mold; a dry, well-ventilated one can run for years
Occupancy	One spider per enclosure, always

Before your tarantula comes home

- ☐ Enclosure set up and running a few hours ahead, water dish filled
- ☐ Legal status checked for your state, city and lease (page 25)
- ☐ A quarantine spot apart from any other invertebrate
- ☐ An exotics vet located, or the honest note that there is none

Emergency & quick targets

ACT NOW IF

The abdomen is shriveled, wrinkled or raisin-like · the legs are curled tightly under an upright body · the spider cannot lift its body · clear fluid is leaking from the abdomen or a joint · it is stuck half out of a molt for hours with no progress · its legs move in a jerky, uncoordinated way · there is white material around the mouth · mold is growing on the spider. Water first, every time.

DO NOT ACT ON ANY OF THESE

Sitting still for days · refusing food for weeks or months with a plump abdomen · lying on its back with legs folded, which is a molt · a bald patch on the abdomen · heavy webbing or sealing itself in · a buried water dish

READING	TARGET
Temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), comfortable to 85°F (29°C)
Water dish	Shallow, full, changed daily
Prey	No larger than the abdomen; out within 24 hours
Around a molt	No food, no handling, no rehousing, no disturbance

Your details

Species, in Latin _____ Sex, and how confirmed _____
 Exotics vet _____ Last molt date _____
 Experienced keeper to call _____ Poison center _____

IF A PERSON IS HURT

Bitten: put the spider down low first, wash the bite with soap and water, cool compress, check the tetanus shot is current; a poison center (1-800-222-1222 in the United States) can advise. Hairs in an eye: do not rub, cover without pressing, and see an eye doctor the same day. Breathing trouble after hair exposure: emergency room the same day (page 31).

Budget & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked in October 2026 and rounded to the nearest \$5. The low end is basic but correct gear.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Enclosure with a secure acrylic lid, never mesh: low and wide for a ground-dweller, taller and cross-ventilated for a pink toe (check the dimensions and the lid before you buy)	\$20 to \$80
Coconut fiber substrate, one or two packs (check the depth against your enclosure)	\$10 to \$35
Cork bark round as the hide, or a pink toe's climbing cork	\$10 to \$30
Two shallow water dishes, one a spare	\$15 to \$30
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$10 to \$20
Long feeding tongs	\$5 to \$15
Vented 32 oz deli cups, for a catch cup and a spare	\$5 to \$20
A large tub to rehouse over	\$5 to \$15
Safety glasses	\$5 to \$15
First feeder insects, crickets or dubia roaches	\$15 to \$35
First bag of gut-load food for the feeders	\$5 to \$10
Setup, before the spider	\$105 to \$305
The tarantula, a beginner species	\$25 to \$100
All in, with the spider	\$130 to \$405

A curly hair or pink toe typically runs \$30 to \$40, a Chilean rose hair \$60 to \$70, and spiderlings cost less than adults. A sexed female costs more and settles the lifespan question (page 24). A stiff card from home seals the catch cup.

ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Feeder insect top-ups, crickets or dubia roaches	\$5 to \$15 a month (\$60 to \$180 a year)
Gut-load food top-ups	\$5 to \$20 a year
Fresh substrate, once or twice a year in a damp setup	\$10 to \$35 a year
Yearly	\$75 to \$235

About \$5 to \$20 a month, and the range depends mostly on the size and appetite of your spider. A dry, well-ventilated setup can run for years on one fill of substrate. No insurer covers a tarantula, and routine vet visits are not part of the budget. A small emergency fund is still worth having.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The enclosure shape and the depth of substrate, because between them they decide the fall risk. Spend on getting the box right and on enough substrate to fill it properly, and save on decor.

First 30 days

Most of this list is things not to do, which is a fair description of tarantula keeping.

Day 1

- ☐ Move the spider from its shipping cup with the cup and card, low over a tub (page 21)
- ☐ Water dish full; lid on; leave it alone in a dark, quiet room. No food on day one
- ☐ Ask the seller for the last molt and feeding dates and write them down
- ☐ Fill in the emergency card (page 33)
- ☐ Start quarantine if any other invertebrate lives here (page 20)

Week 1

- ☐ Top up the water dish daily. That is the whole daily routine
- ☐ Photograph the abdomen from above while it looks healthy (page 16)
- ☐ Read the thermometer and hygrometer, and fix anything out of range

Weeks 2 to 4

- ☐ Offer one prey item of the right size; take it out within 24 hours if ignored. Refusal now is ordinary (page 15)
- ☐ Start the Owner Log, one row per offer (page 40)
- ☐ Leave the webbing and any rearranged substrate as the spider left it
- ☐ Watch for a darkening abdomen and a bald patch: the first premolt may come within weeks (page 22)

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Look at the abdomen from above and adjust the feeding interval
- ☐ Keep the first shed skin and have it sexed (page 24)
- ☐ Keep quarantine going until it has fed, drunk and settled, before sharing tools or a room
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet before you need it (page 39)

Symptom quick reference

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Shriveled, wrinkled abdomen	Dehydration	Large shallow dish of water now (page 27)
Legs curled tightly under an upright body	Death curl, advanced dehydration	Emergency: water within reach immediately
On its back, legs folded over	Molting. Normal	Nothing. No touching, no food (page 22)
Clear fluid on the abdomen or a joint	Hemolymph loss from a fall or injury	Cornstarch on a minor leak; specialist if worse (page 28)
Half out of the old skin for hours, no progress	Stuck molt	Experienced keeper or exotics vet. Never pull (page 23)
Jerky, uncoordinated or twitching legs	Pesticide exposure or DKS	Move away from the source, ventilate (page 30)
White material around the mouth	Oral nematodes	Isolate at once, own tools, vet if available (page 29)
Fuzzy growth on the spider	Mold	Clean, dry, ventilated container with water; vet if available
Mites on the spider itself	Mites on the spider	Vet with invertebrate experience; no chemicals
Mites or flies on prey remains	Something rotting	Remove remains, improve airflow (page 11)
Off food, abdomen plump, bald patch	Premolt. Normal	Stop offering food; keep water full
Off food, abdomen shrunken	Dehydration, not fasting	Water first, today
Juvenile off food 6 to 8+ weeks, losing condition	Possible illness	Vet consult (page 15)
Abdomen very round and full	Well fed, possibly overfed	Feed less often (page 16)
Mature male: palp bulbs, wandering, off food	After his final molt	Normal end-of-life pattern (page 24)
Sitting motionless for days	Normal behavior	Nothing. Judge the setup, not the activity
Rearing up, flicking hairs, showing fangs	Defensive display	Close the enclosure, come back later (page 18)
Buried water dish, webbed-over hide	Normal remodeling	Dig out and refill the dish; leave the web

Daily, weekly & yearly routine

The shortest routine of any pet, and the daily part is the part that matters.

Daily

- ☐ Look at the water dish, change it and top it up.
This prevents the leading cause of death
- ☐ Look at the spider: where it is, the shape of the abdomen, whether it moves normally
- ☐ If prey went in yesterday, take out whatever is left

Weekly

- ☐ Feed on the interval for the spider's stage, unless it is in premolt (page 12)
- ☐ Lift out boluses, prey remains and droppings with tongs
- ☐ Read the thermometer and hygrometer
- ☐ Log offers, refusals and anything noticed (page 40)
- ☐ Check the abdomen's shape, and look for a bald patch

Monthly

- ☐ Dampen a corner of the substrate if the enclosure has dried out
- ☐ Check that the lid still locks and the ventilation holes are clear
- ☐ Look for mold spots and remove them with the substrate under them

Every 6 to 12 months

- ☐ Replace the substrate in a damp setup, or at the first mold, timed away from any molt; a dry, well-ventilated one can run for years (page 11)
- ☐ Check the enclosure is still at least three times the leg span

Every molt

- ☐ Log the date, keep the shed skin, and have it sexed if you don't know yet (page 41)

Always

- ☐ No insect spray, fogger, plug-in or pet flea treatment in the spider's room (page 30)
- ☐ No direct sun on the enclosure in any season

Power outages, travel, transport & shipping

A tarantula needs nothing running, so an outage is a non-event in most homes. The real risk is in a car or a shipping box.

When the power goes out

Pet tarantulas are comfortable across roughly 70 to 85°F (21 to 29°C), which describes an ordinary room for most of the year. An outage only matters if the house turns cold in winter. Then put warm blankets over the enclosure, leaving the ventilation clear, and move it to the warmest interior room. Treat a multi-day cold snap, not the outage itself, as the emergency. Don't add a heat source with no thermostat, and don't feed while it is cold.

Leaving town

A healthy adult already fasts through every molt, so missed meals are not the constraint. **Water is.** Refill the dish with fresh water the morning you go, check that the lid is secure, and don't pre-feed extra insects, which only leaves live prey loose with nobody watching. Slings dry out faster and eat more often, so get someone in sooner for them.

Transport and moving

- A secure, ventilated, escape-proof container, never a loose box or an open cup, lined with soft substrate or folded paper towel so it cannot slide on a bare surface.
- Wedge it upright so it cannot tip or roll, and keep it in the passenger area with you, never in a trunk.
- No hot or freezing parked car, even briefly. The temperature swing inside one happens faster than most people expect.
- By hand, move slowly and low, over a bed or table, never over a hard floor.
- Never move a spider in premolt, mid-molt or freshly molted if it can be postponed.
- Moving house: set the enclosure up at the new place first, then move the spider in its travel container and rehouse it there.

Shipping

USPS, the United States Postal Service, will not carry a tarantula: its mailing standards make all spiders nonmailable. The hobby ships through other carriers' live-animal programs instead, each with its own packaging and timing rules, so check the carrier's current terms yourself. Two federal frameworks can apply by species: USDA APHIS (the United States Department of Agriculture's Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service) permits for moving plant-feeding invertebrates between states, and the injurious wildlife list kept under the Lacey Act. State law adds its own layer. When buying, ask the seller how and when they ship and what their live-arrival policy is.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

There is very little to do, and the most useful instruction on this page is to leave the spider alone. Walk the sitter through it once in person.

Spider's name and species _____

Exotics vet, if there is one _____

My phone _____

Feed on these dates, if any _____

Backup contact _____

Where the feeders are _____

Each visit

- ☐ Change and top up the water dish. This is the important one, and often the only thing that needs doing. Lift the lid, pour carefully, close the lid.
- ☐ Find the spider and check it looks normal. It may be inside its hide or burrow, and that is fine.
- ☐ Feeding only on a marked date: drop in _____ and leave it. If anything is left next visit, tell me rather than reaching in for it.
- ☐ Check the lid is closed and locked before you leave the room. Wash your hands afterward.

Please don't

- Touch, handle, move or "help" the spider for any reason.
- Open the enclosure to look closer, or lean your face over it. It can flick irritating hairs into your eyes. Take photos through the side instead.
- Feed anything not written on this sheet.
- Mist, add water anywhere but the dish, or change anything in the enclosure. Overwatering is a more common sitter mistake than underwatering.
- Tidy the webbing, the rearranged soil or a buried water dish. That is the spider's own work.
- Use any bug spray or flea treatment in this room.
- Worry if it hasn't moved. Sitting still for days is normal.

CALL ME IF

It is out of its enclosure · the water dish has spilled or run dry · its belly looks shriveled or wrinkled · its legs are curled up tightly underneath it · there is clear fluid leaking from it · it is lying on its back (usually a normal molt, but tell me and don't touch it) · it looks stuck half out of an old skin · it is moving in a jerky, uncoordinated way · it has fallen · the lid won't close properly. If I don't answer, call the backup contact.

The record of what went in, what was taken and what the abdomen looked like is the whole clinical history of a tarantula. When a spider has refused food for two months, the log tells you whether that is the fourth premolt fast in three years or something new.

The spider

Molts

[illegible]

Equipment & vet log

Equipment and enclosure

TASK	LAST DONE	DUE	DONE
Substrate replaced (every 6 to 12 months if damp, or at the first mold)			
Rehoused or moved up a size			
Thermometer and hygrometer battery			
Quarantine ended (fed, drunk and settled)			

Vet or keeper consults

DATE	REASON AND FINDINGS	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Substrate depth and enclosure type matched to the species
- ☐ Water dish always full, every species
- ☐ A retreat the spider can web into and modify
- ☐ Floor area beyond the minimum, with no added fall height
- ☐ Low, anchored structure: cork flats, leaf litter, moss

Monthly review

- ☐ Leave anything the spider has built
- ☐ Release live prey rather than presenting it, at varied times
- ☐ Check nothing has shifted or can fall onto the spider
- ☐ Judge the setup on substrate, humidity, airflow and water, not on activity (page 19)

Enrichment log

DATE	WHAT CHANGED	WHAT THE SPIDER DID WITH IT

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't keep a burrowing species on shallow substrate for the view, give a ground-dweller height it can fall from, let the water dish run dry, or leave live prey in with a spider in premolt. And don't read a motionless tarantula as evidence of anything at all.

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to H

Abdomen	The rear, rounded section of the body, covered by thin cuticle. Its size is the feeding gauge, and its shape is the hydration gauge. Pages 16, 27.
Arboreal	Tree-dwelling. An arboreal tarantula such as the pink toe needs a tall enclosure, vertical cork and strong cross-ventilation. Page 7.
Bolus	The small pellet of empty exoskeleton left after a meal. Lift it out with tongs. Page 12.
Book lungs	The paired breathing organs on the underside of the abdomen. They take air straight from the room, which is why insecticide fumes reach a spider. Pages 24, 30.
Captive-bred	Hatched from parents kept by people rather than taken from the wild. Less likely to carry oral nematodes. Page 20.
Carapace	The hard plate covering the top of the front half of the body. A sling's ventilation holes must be smaller than it. Page 7.
CITES	The Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora: the treaty that controls trade in listed animals between countries. Its Appendix II lists species whose trade is regulated. Pages 5, 25.
Cross-ventilation	Ventilation holes on opposite sides of an enclosure, so air moves through it instead of sitting. Pages 7, 9.
Death curl	Legs curled tightly under an upright body: a sign of advanced dehydration and an emergency. Not the same as a spider molting on its back. Page 27.
Deli cup	A clear plastic food cup with a lid, used to house slings. Sold by volume in ounces. Page 7.
DKS	Dyskinetic syndrome: a poorly understood loss of motor coordination, often fatal, with no established treatment. Its signs overlap with pesticide poisoning. Page 30.
Dram	A unit of volume used to size small plastic vials for slings. Page 7.
Exuvia	The shed exoskeleton left after a molt, a hollow copy of the spider. The best way to sex it. Pages 22, 24.
Gut-loading	Feeding the feeder insects well for a day or two before they are offered. The only route nutrition has into a tarantula, since dusting does not apply. Page 14.
Hardening	The days after a molt while the new exoskeleton and fangs firm up: 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults. No food, no handling. Page 23.
Hemolymph	The tarantula equivalent of blood. It flows freely through the body cavity rather than in vessels, so a ruptured abdomen is so often fatal. Page 28.

REFERENCE

Glossary, I to Z

Leg span	The standard measure of a tarantula: diagonally from the tip of a front leg to the tip of the opposite back leg. Enclosures are sized to it. Page 6.
Mature male	A male after his final molt, with bulbs on his palps and, in many species, hooks under the first legs. He never molts again and has a short time left. Page 24.
Molt	Shedding the whole exoskeleton to grow. The molt itself takes 15 minutes to several hours. Page 22.
New World, Old World	Tarantulas from the Americas, and from Africa and Asia. New World species defend with urticating hairs; Old World species have none and rely on a stronger bite. This package covers New World species. Page 5.
Oral nematodes	Microscopic parasitic worms that infect the mouth, mostly in wild-caught spiders. A vet can remove them under anesthesia, but no cure is documented once an infection has taken hold. Page 29.
Palps	Short for pedipalps: the pair of short, leg-like feelers beside the fangs. A mature male's end in swollen bulbs. Page 24.
Premolt	The weeks or months before a molt: refused food, a dark and swollen abdomen, a bald patch, heavy webbing. Page 22.
Quarantine	Keeping a new spider apart from any other invertebrate, with its own tools, until it has fed, drunk and settled. Page 20.
Sling	A spiderling: a young tarantula under about 2 in (5 cm), housed in a vial or deli cup. Page 7.
Spermathecae	A female's sperm-storage organs. Their lining shows in her shed skin as a flap between the book lungs. Page 24.
Terrestrial	Ground-dwelling. A wide, low enclosure mostly full of substrate. Most species in this package. Page 6.
Thermostat	A switch that holds a heater at a set temperature by reading a probe. Required on any heat mat. Page 8.
Units	°F, degrees Fahrenheit, and °C, degrees Celsius, for temperature; in (inches) and cm (centimeters) for size; % (percent) for humidity; drams and ounces for sling containers. Page 34 lists prices in United States dollars.
Urticating hairs	Barbed hairs a New World tarantula kicks off its abdomen at a threat. They irritate skin, eyes and airways. Pages 17, 31.
USDA APHIS	The United States Department of Agriculture's Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service, which permits the movement of plant-feeding invertebrates between states.
USPS	The United States Postal Service, which does not accept spiders for mailing.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary and medical references

- University of Illinois College of Veterinary Medicine: Caring for Pet Tarantulas. The 70 to 85°F comfort range, the daily water dish, the fast before a molt, and oral nematodes.
- Tree of Life Exotic Pet Medical Center: tarantula care. Feeding by age, the post-molt hardening windows, and tall enclosures with cross-ventilation for tree-dwellers.
- Royal Veterinary College, Beaumont Sainsbury Animal Hospital: tarantula care. Pinky mice left out of the diet, no damp sponges, and no misting the spider directly. Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital: basic tarantula care. The mild venom of New World species.
- StatPearls, from the National Library of Medicine bookshelf: Tarantula Spider Toxicity. Tape for skin, the eye shield, and airway involvement. National Capital Poison Center: tarantula bites and hairs.
- dvm360: basic invertebrate medicine, proceedings, and managing invertebrates in practice: quarantine, and fungal disease from wet substrate. American Veterinary Medical Association: Guidelines for the Euthanasia of Animals, 2020 edition, captive invertebrates.

Research

- Stalter, Dorleus, Milone, Sincage, Skurski and Leeds (2024), PLoS ONE 19(12): e0314501, and its correction: tarantula welfare and environmental complexity in Brazilian black tarantulas.
- Mangat and Newman (2012), New Zealand Medical Journal 125(1364): tarantula hair keratitis. Wilde and Flynn (2021), Digital Journal of Ophthalmology 27(3): tarantula hair keratitis.
- Brühl and colleagues (2021), Scientific Reports: pesticide exposure of insects in nature conservation areas in Germany.
- Baniya and colleagues (2023), microPublication Biology: a tarantula-parasitic nematode, with no documented cure once an infection has taken hold.
- Tarantulas in captivity: raising and breeding, Springer.

REFERENCE

Sources, continued

Keeper references, zoos, and the pesticide, shipping and legal sources.

Husbandry references and zoos

- University of the West Indies, the online guide to the animals of Trinidad and Tobago: the pink-toed tarantula. Its adult size and lifespan, and its life in trees and bushes.
- Tom's Big Spiders, a keeper reference site: how much to feed, premolt, sling husbandry, and sexing from molts. The rose hair's crickets a month and long fasts, why a spider refuses food, sling housing and water, and reading a molt.
- Vet Verified: housing a pet tarantula, and common health issues. Utica Zoo and Happy Hollow Park and Zoo: the Chilean rose-haired tarantula, its size and lifespan. Potawatomi Zoo: the curly hair tarantula, its size and lifespan.

Pesticides, shipping and the law

- National Pesticide Information Center: pyrethrins, fipronil and imidacloprid fact sheets. United States Environmental Protection Agency: safety precautions for total release foggers.
- Species+, the species database run with the CITES Secretariat by a United Nations conservation center: the CITES listings for *Brachypelma*, *Tliltocatl*, *Poecilotheria* and the Chilean rose hair. USPS Publication 52, sections 525 and 526. USDA APHIS: interstate movement of plant pests. United States Fish and Wildlife Service: injurious wildlife listings.
- New York City Health Code § 161.01; Hawaii Revised Statutes § 150A-6.2; Montana Code § 87-5-705; District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j); Rhode Island Code of Regulations 250-RICR-40-05-3; Maine Department of Inland Fisheries and Wildlife, Unrestricted Species List; Oregon Administrative Rules 603-052-1320; and each other state's rules, read on 1 October 2026 (Maine on 5 August 2026).
- Beastly Facts guides, current at publication: the tarantula enclosure setup, feeding, health issues, handling, cost, enrichment and legal guides, and the cross-species invertebrate molting, rehousing, quarantine and cleaning, pesticide hazards, and emergency, travel and shipping guides, plus the gut-loading guide. Prices were last checked in September 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Room temperature	70 to 85°F (a veterinary college); 70 to 78°F (an exotic animal hospital)	70 to 80°F as the target, comfortable to 85°F
Humidity, dry-adapted species	40 to 60%; about 50 to 60% (an exotic animal hospital); published targets up to 65 to 75%	40 to 60% for a rose hair, because airflow matters more and damp breeds mold
Uneaten prey out	Within 24 hours (husbandry references); within about 10 minutes (a veterinary college)	Within 24 hours at the latest, and never overnight around a molt
Juvenile feeding	Three times a week (an exotic animal hospital); once or twice a week (a keeper reference); every 4 to 7 days, then 7 to 14	Every 4 to 7 days when young, then every 7 to 14 days
Adult feeding	Every 7 to 14 days (an exotic animal hospital); a few times a week (a veterinary college); four or five crickets a month for an adult rose hair (a keeper reference)	Every 1 to 2 weeks, adjusted on the abdomen; an adult rose hair may need only four or five crickets a month
Adult enclosure	2 to 3× the leg span across (a housing guide); floor 3 to 4× the leg span (an exotic animal hospital); a 20-gallon tank or larger (a veterinary college)	About 20×10×10 in (51×25×25 cm) as the minimum, larger floor welcome, never taller for a ground-dweller
Male lifespan	About 5 years for a rose hair, 10 at the outside (zoos); up to 10 (a veterinary college); 3 to 8 (an exotic animal hospital)	About 5, 10 at the outside, for a rose hair
Oral nematodes	Removable by a vet under anesthesia, sometimes over several sessions (a veterinary college); no documented cure once an infection has taken hold (a 2023 research report)	Isolate at once, and see an exotics vet where one exists
Gut-loading time	A day or two (tarantula feeding references); 24 to 72 hours, 48 typical (feeder insect references)	A day or two, feeders offered within hours of coming off the food

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 49 pages, scoped to the beginner species. Safety: male rose hair about 5 years, 10 at the outside; quarantine apart, own tools, until the spider has fed, drunk and settled; humidity 40 to 60% rose hair, about 65 to 80% pink toe; comfortable to 85°F (29°C); slings at room temperature, 68 to 75°F (20 to 24°C), no added heat; molt 15 minutes to several hours; a round abdomen means fewer meals; slings drink from damp substrate, bottle cap as first dish; oral nematodes: isolate at once and see a vet, euthanasia by a vet only, never freezing alone; bites: soap and water, tetanus checked; hairs in an eye: never flushed or rubbed, eye doctor the same day. Legal: 52 jurisdictions, Maine's three species, Oregon's continental-stock condition, four states unclear. Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$105 to \$305, \$130 to \$405 with the spider; \$75 to \$235 a year, about \$5 to \$20 a month. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.3, Sep 2026.** Legal: Oregon, New Mexico and New Jersey added to the legality table.
- **2.2, Sep 2026.** Safety: a hair in the eye shielded rather than flushed, with an eye doctor the same day; breathing trouble after hair exposure an emergency room visit; pesticide foggers added; no trip-length day count printed.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Spacing only; no content changed.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 43 pages. Replaced by 3.0.
- **1.0, Sep 2026.** First edition, 22 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an exotics veterinarian who treats invertebrates, and nothing in it should delay professional advice where it is available. The law page is a summary as of October 2026, not legal advice.

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